

ASUS ZenFone 3 Deluxe 5.5 ZS550KL - Bootloader Unlock (2026)

Caizzoo Vista | Validated September 27, 2026

Exact device: ZS550KL / Z01FD / Z018, WW, Snapdragon 625 MSM8953, 64 GB eMMC.

DO NOT use this guide for ZS570KL/Z016 or ZE552KL.

This method was validated on a real phone after many hours of research and failed attempts.

Final result: Device unlocked: true, stock Oreo aboot restored, permanent Magisk root working.

WARNING

Unlocking wipes userdata. Get working Qualcomm EDL 9008 BEFORE modifying aboot. Keep abootbak stock.

Do not flash a full Preburn image. Keep all backups outside the phone.

KEY DISCOVERY

Stock Oreo aboot does not register public oem unlock / unlock-go / flashing unlock commands.

The engineering aboot registers them and checks config[0x7FFF] & 1.

On the real phone: config[0x1FC]=01 and config[0x7FFF]=00.

The safe patch is YOUR OWN config backup with only byte 0x7FFF changed 00 -> 01.

KNOWN SHA-256

stock aboot:

```
1fc963b732cd634c7ebd82246f4938ed40b158ae57a836ec6da2bae24e2bcdcd0
```

engineering aboot:

```
369158325d9e39c88fb5d9969fbb1cd647e476bbbe97130b1be02b63b184d296
```

stock config:

```
319270ac6f9b4c221a620e51bb15a06260957785f8d032f42279a39bf603dab2
```

1. ENTER REAL EDL 9008

The software reboot methods did not reach usable 9008 on the tested phone.

A deep-flash cable worked: temporarily bridge USB D+ to GND while connecting the powered-off phone,

hold Vol+ + Power about 20 seconds, then release the bridge.

NEVER short +5V/VBUS to GND.

PowerShell check:

```
Get-PnpDevice -PresentOnly | Where-Object {$_.InstanceId -match 'VID_05C6'} | Select  
Status,FriendlyName,InstanceId
```

Required: VID_05C6&PID_9008

PID_900E is crash dump, not the final Firehose path.

Use Zadig -> List All Devices -> 05C6:9008 -> WinUSB.

```
qdl.exe list
```

Expected: 05c6:9008 (none)

2. VALIDATE FIREHOSE AND BACK UP

Programmer:

```
Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn
```

Test read:

```
qdl.exe -d -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn read 0/0+34 gpt-primary.bin
```

Back up at minimum: aboot, abootbak, config, devinfo, sysconf, bootparam.

Example:

```
qdl.exe -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn read aboot aboot-edl-backup.img
```

```
qdl.exe -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn read config config-edl-backup.img
```

3. PATCH CONFIG - ONE BYTE ONLY

The config partition is 524288 bytes. Build config-patched.img from your own backup and set:

```
0x7FFF: 00 -> 01
```

Write and read back:

```
qdl.exe -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn write config config-patched.img
```

```
qdl.exe -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn read config config-after-write.img
```

Verify both SHA-256 hashes match.

4. TEMPORARILY FLASH ENGINEERING ABOT

Do NOT touch abootbak.

Verify engineering aboot SHA-256 equals:

```
369158325d9e39c88fb5d9969fbb1cd647e476bbbe97130b1be02b63b184d296
```

```
qdl.exe -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn write aboot aboot.img
```

Read it back and verify the same hash.

5. UNLOCK

Enter Fastboot:

```
fastboot oem device-info
```

```
fastboot flashing get_unlock_ability
```

On the tested unit it initially returned 0. The working sequence was:

```
fastboot flash config H:\qdl\config-patched.img
```

```
fastboot reboot-bootloader
fastboot flashing get_unlock_ability
```

When get_unlock_ability = 1:

```
fastboot oem unlock-go
```

The phone wipes userdata. Afterward:

```
fastboot oem device-info
```

Required result: Device unlocked: true

6. RESTORE STOCK OREO ABOUT

```
qdl.exe -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn write about about-edl-backup.img
```

Read back and verify stock hash:

```
1fc963b732cd634c7ebd82246f4938ed40b158ae57a836ec6da2bae24e2bcdcd0
```

Reboot and confirm Device unlocked: true remains.

OPTIONAL MAGISK ROOT

Read the phone's own boot:

```
qdl.exe -R -s emmc Asus_ZS550KL_prog_emmc_firehose_8953_ddr.mbn read boot boot-stock.img
```

Patch boot-stock.img in Magisk. Test first:

```
fastboot boot magisk_patched-XXXXX.img
```

```
adb shell su -c id
```

If uid=0(root), then:

```
fastboot flash boot magisk_patched-XXXXX.img
```

```
fastboot reboot
```

FAILED / NON-FINAL ROUTES ON THIS PHONE

```
adb reboot edl; reboot edl; RESTART2("edl"); direct Android dd writes to devinfo/config;
PID_900E crash dump alone; stock public unlock commands; old ASUSKEY/FDSSKEY authorization flow.
```

Recovery principle: if Fastboot breaks but 9008 still works, restore YOUR OWN about and config backups.

Never restore device-specific devinfo/sysconf/calibration data from another phone.

Caizzoo Vista - community documentation, use at your own risk.